

legal fees themselves don't seem so bad. Sure, you'll probably spend a few thousand on attorneys' fees and court costs, but anything's better than living with the ol' battle-ax, right?

Wrong. Of the 70,000 divorces in Canada each year, the majority of cases end up snarled in legal snafus, dragged out by arbitrary motions and affidavits. A study by the Law Society of Upper Canada found that when children are involved, it takes an average of three years for a litigated divorce in Ontario to blunder through family court. That's three years of near-constant attorney fees.

If you or your partner own real estate, you can tack on a whole new layer of expenses. There are refinancing costs, record deed fees, and of course there's that pesky attorney again, billing you \$400 an hour to iron out all the kinks.

If you have kids, they are going to be living between two homes. That may not seem like a big deal, but they're going to need more stuff. Now they have two wardrobes, two closets full of clothes—maybe even two computers. And how about all the discounts you got as a couple on the expenses you shared? Car insurance, cell phones, cable, Internet—you're paying for all of that on your own now. Separated couples often report that their expenses increase by \$20,000 to \$30,000 a year.

Money Mistake: *You Want a Divorce*

The Fix: *Give Yourself a 90-Day Cool-Down*

So you caught your partner with someone else. Or maybe you're the one who feels the need to call it quits on your marriage and pursue other options. Whatever happened, once there's a confrontation between you and your partner, tempers are hot and your partnership is sinking faster than a camel in quicksand. One of you speaks the dreaded words "I want a divorce." What happens next?

Don't do anything for 90 days. Remember, right now you are a slave to your emotions, and emotions cost money. I want both of you to take a 90-Day Cool-Down. If you can't bear the sight of your spouse, stay with a friend or relative. Check into a hotel if you must,